the following summer. Beijing rejected the proposal.[26] The Indian army chief at the time, General Krishnaswamy Sundarji, decided it was time for India to show its teeth and sent an entire brigade into Zeimithang just south of the border. Operation Falcon had begun. A helipad was constructed on a hilltop overlooking the Sumdorong Chu Valley, heavy guns were placed in position, and long-range patrols were sent into surrounding areas. According to an Indian Army officer who was on active duty along the border at the time, 'Sundarji wanted to show the Chinese that this is not 1962. He wanted to flex his muscles and demonstrate to the Chinese that it's a different Indian Army they are facing today.'[27]

Indian Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi was alarmed at the developments along the northeastern border and came to the area in October. But he was unable to visit Zeimithang because, the officers said, 'the weather was bad'. Helicopters could not land there. The prime minister had to be content with a briefing at the army camp in Tawang. He reportedly said, 'A nice presentation, but I'm not convinced'.[28] Sundarji did not back down and sent more troops and heavy artillery into the area.

By early 1987, the Chinese had moved 20,000 of their troops to the mountains overlooking the Sumdorong Chu Valley, and Indian and Chinese soldiers were also standing literally face-to-face at Bumla and other mountain passes. The situation was not defused until Narayan Dutt Tawari, then Indian minister of External Affairs, stopped over in Beijing in May of that year on his way to North Korea's capital, Pyongyang. As a result, the two sides met at Bumla on 5 August and decided to solve problems over border incidents through talks rather than armed confrontation.

It is extremely rare for an Indian army officer to challenge the elected government like Sundarji did in 1986–7, but that was such an occasion. When Sundarji died in 1999, *India Today* published an obituary saying that his

> place in history will probably rest on the lesser-known Operation Falcon …Western diplomats predicted war and Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi's advisers charged that Sundarji's recklessness was responsible for this. But the general stood firm, at one point telling a senior Rajiv aide, "Please make alternate arrangements if you think you are not getting adequate professional advice." The civilians backed off, so did the Chinese.[29]

The Chinese were far more careful in their dealings with Indians after the confrontation in the Sumdorong Chu Valley. Rajiv Gandhi, invited by